A Constructive Introduction to Quantum Field Theory

Lecture 5: Φ^4_3 on the torus I. The Wetterich FBSDE, two renormalisations and the large-field problem

BY M. GUBINELLI

Mathematical Institute, University of Oxford

November 2026 — provisional

Abstract

The last two lectures construct the massive Φ^4_3 measure on the three-dimensional torus with the forward–backward equations of Lecture 4. In this lecture we set up the problem. For the mass regulator the Polchinski process of Lecture 4 is the linear estimator $C_q P_q$ built from noisy observations of the field, and its forecast is their posterior mean; this gives an exact FBSDE at every lattice cutoff. Its backward half is governed by the Wetterich equation. We cannot solve that equation, so we construct an explicit approximate effective average action and write the exact FBSDE in the coordinates it defines: the *approximate forecast* Y and the *error* Z. The error is driven only by the failure of the approximate action to solve the Wetterich equation. We explain why the approximate action needs two renormalisations, in two senses: a linearly and a logarithmically divergent mass counterterm, and two correction steps beyond one loop, which make the defect integrable in the backward equation. Finally we identify the large-field problem: the construction only controls fields of size $r_q = (q/\gamma)^{1/2}$, and must be extended to all fields without losing coercivity. The price is an error that is not small but lives on large fields. Lecture 6 controls it by a priori estimates on the FBSDE and removes the cutoffs.

Table of contents

Introduction . . . 2

What is proved . . . 3

10 The problem and the exact FBSDE . . . 3

10.1 Lattice, scales and notation . . . 3

The resolution parameter . . . 3

10.2 The cutoff measure and the goal . . . 4

10.3 The Polchinski process as a posterior . . . 4

10.4 The Wetterich formulation . . . 6

10.5 Approximate forecast and error . . . 6

Reading (10.16) . . . 7

Exercises . . . 7

11 Renormalisation: why two of them . . . 8

11.1 Scales and power counting . . . 8

The basic loop estimate . . . 8

11.2 The seed: one loop . . . 9

11.3 Corrections and the mass . . . 9

The quadratic part . . . 10

11.4 Two mass renormalisations . . . 11

11.5 Two correction steps . . . 12
Exercises . . . 12

12 The flow at large fields . . . 13

12.1 The large-field problem . . . 13
A scalar model . . . 13
12.2 Clipping . . . 13
12.3 The complete defect . . . 14
Where the large-field error comes from . . . 14
The coordinate correction . . . 15
12.4 Why the Polchinski expansion is not enough . . . 15
The exact force is linear at large fields . . . 15
The field equation does not see the cube . . . 16
What clipping does to the Polchinski equation . . . 16
Integrating the cube . . . 17
What this says about the choice of equation . . . 18
12.5 Summary . . . 19
Exercises . . . 20

References . . . 20

Introduction

Lecture 4 formulated a programme (Figure 7.1 and the remark following it): solve the FBSDE

$$\Phi_t = \int_0^t \dot{Q}_s F_s \, \mathrm{d}s + \int_0^t \dot{Q}_s^{1/2} \mathrm{d}W_s, \qquad F_t = \mathbb{E}_t[-D V_T(\Phi_T)],$$

with a renormalised interaction V_T, with estimates uniform in the ultraviolet cutoff, and take the limit. For Φ_3^4 the force F_t is not expected to converge to an integrable terminal value, and the naive estimates of the force diverge (Appendix A.2 of Lecture 4). In these two lectures we carry out a version of the programme on the unit torus $\mathbb{T}^3$, for a large mass. The guiding principle is the one of Section 8: do not estimate Φ and F directly, but pass to the forecast coordinate, in which the forward equation has no drift and the tree diagrams have been integrated exactly. Section 12.4 shows on one site what goes wrong with a frozen cube, and what integrating it gives.

The argument has three parts, over two lectures.

i. *Deterministic renormalisation* (this lecture). Construct an explicit approximate effective average action $\bar{\Gamma}_q$ and a counterterm, by a finite number of steps of the Wetterich flow, and estimate its defect.

ii. *A priori estimates* (Lecture 6). Write the exact FBSDE in the coordinates of $\bar{\Gamma}_q$, turn the forward equation into the field equation of Lecture 4 with its sub-Gaussian noise, and estimate it together with the backward equation, uniformly in the lattice.

iii. *Removing the cutoffs* (Lecture 6). Remove the upper scale at fixed lattice, then the lattice, and identify the limiting FBSDE and its terminal law.

The emphasis is on the structure of the argument. We give complete proofs of the identities and of the scalar models of the estimates, and only describe the tensor estimates on the lattice. The lectures follow the course notes [FBSDE26], where the estimates of this lecture are proved; Lecture 6 takes a shorter forward route than those notes, which use the memory form of its Exercise 13.3. The point of view is that of [BCG26]; for other constructions of Φ_3^4 see [GJ73, FO76, BFS83, BG20, GH21].

What is proved. The construction is for a large mass $m^2 = q_0$ compared to the coupling, $\lambda \ll q_0^{1/2}$: a weak dimensionless coupling on a fixed torus. It gives a subsequential limit of the lattice measures, with a limiting FBSDE driven by a Brownian motion obtained as the limit of the lattice innovations. It does not prove uniqueness of the limit, the Osterwalder–Schrader axioms, or an infinite-volume limit.

10 The problem and the exact FBSDE

10.1 Lattice, scales and notation

Let N be an odd integer and $\Lambda_N = (N^{-1}\mathbb{Z}/\mathbb{Z})^3$ the periodic lattice of mesh N^{-1} in the unit torus. Let $H_N = \mathbb{R}^{\Lambda_N}$ with

$$\langle u, v\rangle = \int u\, v, \qquad \int f := N^{-3} \sum_{x\in\Lambda_N} f(x),$$

so that the volume is 1 and integrals approximate continuum integrals. The nearest-neighbour Laplacian is $\Delta_N u(x) = N^2 \sum_{i=1}^3 [u(x+e_i/N) + u(x-e_i/N) - 2u(x)]$; we usually drop the index N. A kernel $C(x,z)$ acts by $Cu(x) = \int C(x,z)\, u(z)\mathrm{d}z$, so the identity has kernel $N^3 1_{x=z}$, and

$$\mathrm{Tr}C = \int C(x,x)\mathrm{d}x, \qquad (\mathrm{diag}C)(x) = C(x,x), \qquad \|C\|_{\mathrm{row}} = \sup_x \int |C(x,z)|\mathrm{d}z.$$

M_f is multiplication by f, and $K + \gamma y^2$ means $K + \gamma M_{y^2}$. For a functional F on H_N, DF, D^2F, D^kF are its gradient and derivatives, as in Lecture 3. $\|u\|_p$ is the L^p norm for the measure $\int$.

The resolution parameter. Lecture 3 used a general covariance profile. Here we use the *mass-regulator profile* of Exercise 8.9 of Lecture 4: with $m^2 = q_0$ and $t \geq 0$,

$$\hat{Q}_t(k) = \frac{1}{|k|^2 + q_0} - \frac{1}{|k|^2 + q_0 + t^2}, \qquad \mathcal{R}_t = t^2.$$

It is convenient to parametrise the resolution by the squared regulator mass

$$q := q_0 + t^2 \in [q_0, \infty).$$

Set

$$K_q := q - \Delta_N, \qquad C_q := K_q^{-1}, \qquad C := C_{q_0} = (m^2 - \Delta_N)^{-1}. \tag{10.1}$$

In the notation of Lecture 3, with $T = \infty$ and using q instead of t as the resolution variable (so $\dot{Q}$ now means $\partial_q Q_q$),

$$Q_q = C - C_q, \qquad \partial_q Q_q = C_q^2, \qquad \dot{Q}^{1/2} = C_q, \qquad S_q = C_q, \qquad \mathcal{R}_q = q - q_0, \qquad \partial_q \mathcal{R}_q = 1. \tag{10.2}$$

So C_q is the covariance of the scales not yet resolved, and $K_q = S_q^{-1}$ is the precision of the posterior at resolution q under the free prior μ^C. The main properties of C_q are elementary.

Lemma 10.1. (Free resolvents) *For $q \geq 1$, uniformly in N: C_q has a nonnegative kernel, $C_q 1 = q^{-1}1$, $\|C_q\|_{p\to p} = q^{-1}$ for $1 \leq p \leq \infty$, and*

$$a_2(q) := (C_q^2)(x,x) = \mathrm{Tr}C_q^2 \lesssim q^{-1/2} \wedge N^3 q^{-2}, \qquad \mathrm{Tr}C_q \lesssim N \wedge N^3 q^{-1}. \tag{10.3}$$

For $y \in H_N$ and $\gamma > 0$, the killed resolvent $G_q(y) = (K_q + \gamma y^2)^{-1}$ satisfies $0 \leq G_q(y)(x,z) \leq C_q(x,z)$.

Proof. $C_q=\int_0^\infty \mathrm{e}^{-qs}\mathrm{e}^{s\Delta}\mathrm{d}s$ and $\mathrm{e}^{s\Delta}$ is the transition kernel of the lattice random walk. This gives positivity and the row sums. Killing the walk at rate γy^2 gives the comparison for G_q. The symbol of $-\Delta_N$ is comparable to $|k|^2$ on the centred frequency cube $n\in\{-\frac{N-1}{2},\dots,\frac{N-1}{2}\}^3$ (symbol $4N^2\sum_i \sin^2(\pi n_i/N)$, with $k=2\pi n$), and $\sum_k (q+|k|^2)^{-2}\le C\int_{\mathbb{R}^3}(q+|k|^2)^{-2}\mathrm{d}k = Cq^{-1/2}$. Counting the N^3 modes gives the other bounds. □

The *bubble* $a_2(q)$ is the coincident-point variance of the shell at resolution q: $\partial_q \mathrm{Var}(X_q(x)) = a_2(q)$ for the free field at resolution q, and $\int_{q_0}^\infty a_2 = \mathrm{Tr}C_{q_0}\asymp N$ is the divergent variance of the lattice field.

10.2 The cutoff measure and the goal

Fix $\lambda>0$ and put $\gamma:=3\lambda$ (not to be confused with the counterterm γ_T of Lecture 4). The interaction and the lattice measure are

$$U(\varphi)=\frac{\lambda}{4}\int\varphi^4,\qquad V_N(\varphi)=U(\varphi)+\frac{\mu_N}{2}\int\varphi^2,\qquad \nu_N(\mathrm{d}\varphi)=\frac{\mathrm{e}^{-V_N(\varphi)}}{Z_N}\,\mu^C(\mathrm{d}\varphi), \tag{10.4}$$

where μ^C is the centred Gaussian measure with covariance $C=C_{q_0}$ on H_N, and $\mu_N\in\mathbb{R}$ is a mass counterterm to be chosen. With this normalisation $D^2U(y)=\gamma M_{y^2}$. In Lecture 4 we wrote the interaction as $\lambda\int H_4(\varphi;c_T)+\gamma_T\int H_2(\varphi;c_T)$; the Wick ordering is now part of μ_N, and the coupling is rescaled by 4. For every real μ_N, ν_N is a probability measure with all moments, since the quartic term dominates.

Theorem 10.2. (Main result, informal [FBSDE26]) *Let $\lambda>0$ and let q_0 be large enough, depending on λ. There are explicit μ_N, with $\mu_N=-3\lambda\mathrm{Tr}C+O(\log N)$, such that:*

a) the laws ν_N, embedded in $H^{-s}(\mathbb{T}^3)$, are tight for every $s>\frac12$;

b) along a subsequence, the forecast processes converge, on a common probability space, to a solution of a forward–backward system on $[q_0,\infty)$ driven by a cylindrical Brownian motion, whose terminal value has the limiting law ν;

c) ν satisfies the integration by parts formula of Theorem 18.5, in which the renormalised cube appears only tested in expectation.

The bounds that prove (a) and (b) are uniform in N: this is *UV stability*. They are bounds on the *error* Z of an approximate forecast, defined below. We now set up the exact FBSDE at fixed N.

10.3 The Polchinski process as a posterior

At a fixed lattice everything can be realised by a simple statistical experiment. Let $\Phi_\infty\sim\nu_N$, and let B be an independent Brownian motion on H_N, $\mathbb{E}\,\langle B_t,u\rangle\langle B_s,v\rangle=(t\wedge s)\langle u,v\rangle$. We observe

$$P_q=(q-q_0)\,\Phi_\infty+B_{q-q_0},\qquad q\ge q_0, \tag{10.5}$$

with the filtration $\mathcal{F}_q$ generated by $(P_s)_{s\le q}$ (completed), and $\mathbb{E}_q=\mathbb{E}[\,\cdot\,|\mathcal{F}_q]$. Let

$$\mathcal{K}_q(p):=\log\int \mathrm{e}^{\langle p,\varphi\rangle-\frac{q-q_0}{2}\|\varphi\|_2^2}\nu_N(\mathrm{d}\varphi),\qquad \nu_{q,p}(\mathrm{d}\varphi):=\mathrm{e}^{\langle p,\varphi\rangle-\frac{q-q_0}{2}\|\varphi\|_2^2-\mathcal{K}_q(p)}\nu_N(\mathrm{d}\varphi). \tag{10.6}$$

Proposition 10.3. (Posterior, forecast and innovation) *At every fixed N:*

a) the conditional law of Φ_∞ given $\mathcal{F}_q$ is ν_{q,P_q}. In particular the forecast *and the* conditional covariance *are*

$$\psi_q:=\mathbb{E}_q\Phi_\infty=D\mathcal{K}_q(P_q),\qquad \mathrm{Cov}_q:=\mathrm{Cov}(\Phi_\infty|\mathcal{F}_q)=D^2\mathcal{K}_q(P_q)>0; \tag{10.7}$$

b) *the* innovation $W_q := P_q - \int_{q_0}^{q} \psi_s \mathrm{d}s$ *is an* $(\mathcal{F}_q)$*-Brownian motion on* H_N*, and*

$$\mathrm{d}P_q = \psi_q \,\mathrm{d}q + \mathrm{d}W_q, \qquad \mathrm{d}\psi_q = \mathrm{Cov}_q \,\mathrm{d}W_q; \tag{10.8}$$

c) $\mathcal{K}$ *solves* $\partial_q \mathcal{K}_q + \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}D^2 \mathcal{K}_q + \frac{1}{2}\|D\mathcal{K}_q\|_2^2 = 0$.

Proof. (a) Conditionally on $\Phi_\infty = \varphi$, the density of the observed path on $[q_0, q]$ with respect to the law of B is $\exp\{\langle P_q, \varphi\rangle - \frac{q-q_0}{2}\|\varphi\|^2\}$ (Girsanov, or a direct computation on finitely many increments). Bayes' formula gives ν_{q,P_q}, and differentiating $\mathcal{K}_q$ in p gives the conditional moments. Positivity of Cov_q holds because $\nu_{q,p}$ has a positive density. (b) For $s < q$, $\mathbb{E}_s[P_q - P_s] = (q-s)\,\psi_s$ since B has independent increments, and $\mathbb{E}_s \int_s^q \psi_u \mathrm{d}u = (q-s)\,\psi_s$ since ψ is a martingale. So W is a continuous martingale with $\mathrm{d}\langle W, W\rangle_q = I\,\mathrm{d}q$, and Lévy's theorem applies. (c) $\partial_q \mathcal{K} = -\frac{1}{2}\,\mathbb{E}_{\nu_{q,p}}\|\varphi\|^2$ and $\mathrm{Tr}D^2\mathcal{K} = \mathbb{E}_{\nu_{q,p}}\|\varphi\|^2 - \|D\mathcal{K}\|^2$. Differentiating (c) in p and applying Itô's formula along $\mathrm{d}P = D\mathcal{K}(P)\mathrm{d}q + \mathrm{d}W$, the drift of $D\mathcal{K}_q(P_q)$ cancels, which gives $\mathrm{d}\psi = \mathrm{Cov}\,\mathrm{d}W$. □

The observation P_q is not yet the field of Lecture 4. The posterior (10.6) is ν_N tilted by a Gaussian factor of precision $q - q_0$: the remaining randomness has precision $K_{q_0} + (q - q_0) = K_q$. This suggests the following.

Proposition 10.4. (The Polchinski process) *Let* $\Phi_q := C_q P_q$ *and* $F_q := K_q(\psi_q - \Phi_q)$*. Then*

$$\mathrm{d}\Phi_q = C_q^2 F_q \,\mathrm{d}q + C_q \,\mathrm{d}W_q, \qquad F_q = \mathbb{E}_q[-D V_N(\Phi_\infty)], \qquad \psi_q = \Phi_q + C_q F_q. \tag{10.9}$$

This is the FBSDE (7.7) of Lecture 4 for the profile (10.2): Φ *is the interacting field at resolution* q*,* F *the effective force,* ψ *the forecast of Proposition 8.1, and* $\mathrm{Cov}_q = H_q^{\mathrm{ex}}(\psi_q)$ *(Proposition 10.5) is the response of Proposition 8.3. Under* $\nu_N = \mu^C$ *one has* $F = 0$*,* $\Phi_q = \psi_q$*, and* Φ_q *is the Gaussian field* X_q *of Proposition 5.2 of Lecture 3, with law* μ^{Q_q}*.*

Proof. $\mathrm{d}\Phi_q = -C_q^2 P_q \,\mathrm{d}q + C_q(\psi_q \mathrm{d}q + \mathrm{d}W_q) = C_q(\psi_q - \Phi_q)\mathrm{d}q + C_q \mathrm{d}W_q$, which is the first identity. For the second, integrate by parts in the density of $\nu_{q,p}$ with respect to Lebesgue measure, $\exp\{\langle p, \varphi\rangle - \frac{1}{2}\langle \varphi, K_q \varphi\rangle - V_N(\varphi)\}$: there is no boundary term, and

$$p = K_q\, D\mathcal{K}_q(p) + \int D V_N \,\mathrm{d}\nu_{q,p}. \tag{10.10}$$

At $p = P_q = K_q \Phi_q$ this reads $K_q(\psi_q - \Phi_q) = \mathbb{E}_q[-D V_N(\Phi_\infty)]$. In the Gaussian case the posterior is $\mu^{C_q}(\cdot - C_q P_q)$, so $\psi = \Phi$ and $\Phi_\infty - \Phi_q$ is independent of $\mathcal{F}_q$ with covariance C_q. Hence Φ_q is a Gaussian martingale with covariance $C - C_q = Q_q$. In general both the law of $(\Phi_\infty, (\Phi_q)_q)$ here and the law of $(X_\infty, (X_q)_q)$ under the measure $\mathbb{P}$ of Proposition 7.2 are the Gaussian law tilted by the same function $\mathrm{e}^{-V_N}/\mathcal{Z}_N$ of the terminal field, so they coincide. Since $P_q = K_q \Phi_q$, the filtration $(\mathcal{F}_q)$ is also the one generated by Φ. □

So at a fixed lattice the FBSDE of Lecture 4 is a *theorem*, with a Brownian motion W which is explicitly the innovation of a filtering problem. All objects of Section 8 have a statistical meaning:

Lecture 4	filtering at resolution q
field Φ_q	$C_q P_q$: posterior mean under the Gaussian prior μ^C
forecast ψ_q	posterior mean $\mathbb{E}_q \Phi_\infty$
response $H_q^{\mathrm{ex}}(\psi_q) = \mathrm{Cov}_q$	posterior covariance
force $F_q = K_q(\psi_q - \Phi_q)$	posterior mean of the terminal force $-D V_N(\Phi_\infty)$
Brownian motion W	innovation $P_q - \int \psi$
unresolved covariance $S_q = C_q$	prior precision plus observation precision, inverted

The observations need no ultraviolet regularity: P_q is defined for every q, with terminal resolution ∞ at fixed N. The lattice is the only ultraviolet cutoff, and $\Phi_q \to \Phi_\infty$ as $q \to \infty$ (Lemma 16.1).

10.4 The Wetterich formulation

Let $\Psi_q := \mathscr{K}_q^*$ be the Legendre transform of the log-partition function and

$$\Gamma_q(y) := \Psi_q(y) - \tfrac{1}{2}\langle y, K_q y\rangle, \qquad H_q^{\mathrm{ex}}(y) := (K_q + D^2\Gamma_q(y))^{-1}. \tag{10.11}$$

Comparing with (8.11), and using $S_q^{-1} = K_q$, Γ_q is, up to a function of q alone, the Γ_t of Lecture 4: $\Gamma_q + \frac{1}{2}\langle y, K_{q_0} y\rangle$ is the effective average action with the regulator $\mathscr{R}_q = q - q_0$ (Exercise 10.1). The coordinate identity $P_q = D\Psi_q(\psi_q)$ reads

$$K_q\Phi_q = K_q\psi_q + D\Gamma_q(\psi_q), \qquad \text{i.e.} \qquad \Phi_q = \psi_q + C_q D\Gamma_q(\psi_q), \tag{10.12}$$

which is (8.5) with $\mathscr{F}_q = D\Gamma_q$.

Proposition 10.5. (Wetterich equation with a mass regulator) *At fixed N, Γ_q is smooth and strictly convex after adding $\frac{1}{2}\langle y, K_q y\rangle$, and*

$$\partial_q\Gamma_q(y) = \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}H_q^{\mathrm{ex}}(y), \qquad \mathrm{Cov}_q = H_q^{\mathrm{ex}}(\psi_q). \tag{10.13}$$

Proof. $\mathscr{K}_q$ is smooth, strictly convex (its Hessian is a covariance) and superlinear (the posterior has full support), so Ψ_q is smooth and $D^2\Psi_q(D\mathscr{K}(p)) = (D^2\mathscr{K}(p))^{-1}$. By the envelope theorem at fixed y and Proposition 10.3(c), $\partial_q\Psi_q(y) = -\partial_q\mathscr{K}_q(p) = \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}D^2\mathscr{K}_q(p) + \frac{1}{2}\|y\|^2$, with $p = D\Psi_q(y)$. Subtract $\partial_q\frac{1}{2}\langle y, K_q y\rangle = \frac{1}{2}\|y\|^2$. □

This is (8.12) with $\partial_q\mathscr{R} = 1$, up to the constant $-\frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}C_q$ (which is infinite in the continuum and irrelevant here). It is an identity about the unknown measure ν_N, not a construction: to use it we would need estimates on Γ_q, which is what we want to prove. Lecture 4 suggests the strategy: since the FBSDE in forecast coordinates is

$$\mathrm{d}\psi_q = \mathrm{Cov}_q\,\mathrm{d}W_q, \qquad \mathrm{Cov}_q = H_q^{\mathrm{ex}}(\psi_q),$$

an *approximate* effective action gives approximate forecast coordinates, and the error should be governed by how badly the approximate action fails to solve (10.13).

10.5 Approximate forecast and error

Let $\bar\Gamma_q$ be an even functional on H_N, smooth in q and y, such that $\bar\Psi_q(y) = \frac{1}{2}\langle y, K_q y\rangle + \bar\Gamma_q(y)$ is uniformly convex, $D^2\bar\Psi_q \geq \underline{c}_q I$ with $\underline{c}_q > 0$. Let $\bar{\mathscr{K}}_q = \bar\Psi_q^*$ and define the *approximate response*, the *defect* and its drift

$$H_q(y) := (K_q + D^2\bar\Gamma_q(y))^{-1},$$
$$e_q(y) := \partial_q\bar\Gamma_q(y) - \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}[H_q(y) - H_q(0)], \qquad b_q(y) := -H_q(y)\,De_q(y). \tag{10.14}$$

The subtraction of $H_q(0)$ only removes a function of q. Define the *approximate forecast* and the *error*

$$Y_q := D\bar{\mathscr{K}}_q(P_q), \qquad Z_q := \psi_q - Y_q, \qquad \Xi_q := \mathrm{Cov}_q - H_q(Y_q). \tag{10.15}$$

Equivalently Y_q solves the approximate coordinate equation $K_q\Phi_q = K_q Y_q + D\bar\Gamma_q(Y_q)$, i.e. (10.12) with $\bar\Gamma$ in place of Γ. If $\bar\Gamma = \Gamma$ then $Y = \psi$, $Z = 0$, and e depends only on q, so $b = 0$.

Theorem 10.6. (The FBSDE in approximate forecast coordinates) *At every fixed N,*

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{d}Y_q &= [b_q(Y_q) + H_q(Y_q)\, Z_q]\mathrm{d}q + H_q(Y_q)\, \mathrm{d}W_q, \\ \mathrm{d}Z_q &= -[b_q(Y_q) + H_q(Y_q)\, Z_q]\mathrm{d}q + \Xi_q\, \mathrm{d}W_q, \end{aligned} \tag{10.16}$$

with $Y_{q_0} = Z_{q_0} = 0$, and $Y + Z = \psi$ is the martingale $\int \mathrm{Cov}\, \mathrm{d}W$.

Proof. By the Legendre identities $\partial_q \bar{\mathcal{K}}_q(p) = -\partial_q \bar{\Psi}_q(y) = -\frac{1}{2}\|y\|^2 - \partial_q \bar{\Gamma}_q(y)$ and $D^2 \bar{\mathcal{K}}_q(p) = H_q(y)$ at $y = D\bar{\mathcal{K}}_q(p)$. Hence

$$\partial_q \bar{\mathcal{K}}_q + \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr} D^2 \bar{\mathcal{K}}_q + \tfrac{1}{2}\|D\bar{\mathcal{K}}_q\|^2 = -\left(\partial_q \bar{\Gamma}_q - \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr} H_q\right) \circ D\bar{\mathcal{K}}_q = -e_q \circ D\bar{\mathcal{K}}_q + \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr} H_q(0).$$

Differentiate in p: $\partial_q D\bar{\mathcal{K}} + \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr} D^2(D\bar{\mathcal{K}}) + D^2\bar{\mathcal{K}}\, D\bar{\mathcal{K}} = -H\, De = b$. Now apply Itô's formula to $Y_q = D\bar{\mathcal{K}}_q(P_q)$ along $\mathrm{d}P = \psi\, \mathrm{d}q + \mathrm{d}W$:

$$\mathrm{d}Y_q = \left[\partial_q D\bar{\mathcal{K}} + \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr} D^2(D\bar{\mathcal{K}})\right]\mathrm{d}q + D^2\bar{\mathcal{K}}\,(\psi_q \mathrm{d}q + \mathrm{d}W_q) = [b_q - H_q Y_q + H_q \psi_q]\mathrm{d}q + H_q\, \mathrm{d}W_q,$$

which is the first equation, since $\psi - Y = Z$. The second is $\mathrm{d}Z = \mathrm{d}\psi - \mathrm{d}Y$ and (10.8). At $q = q_0$, $P_{q_0} = 0$ and evenness give $Y_{q_0} = 0 = \psi_{q_0}$. □

Reading (10.16). The equation for Y is forward and explicit, once Z is known: its coefficients b, H are deterministic functions built from $\bar{\Gamma}$. The equation for Z is backward. Its terminal condition is not imposed but *proved*: if $\bar{\Gamma}_q$ matches the bare action as $q \to \infty$, then $qZ_q \to 0$ at each fixed N (Lemma 16.1). Its only source is the drift b, i.e. the gradient of the defect, transported by the propagator $\exp \int H$. So:

UV stability means that the explicit action $\bar{\Gamma}$ computes the forecast up to an error Z which is small uniformly in N.

For this we need: (i) a defect e whose gradient is integrable against the backward propagator, which is a deterministic renormalisation problem (Section 11); (ii) global coercivity of $\bar{\Gamma}$, so that $H_q(y)$ is a good noise coefficient for all fields (Section 12); (iii) a priori estimates for the coupled system (Lecture 6). Figure 10.1 summarises the logic of the two lectures.

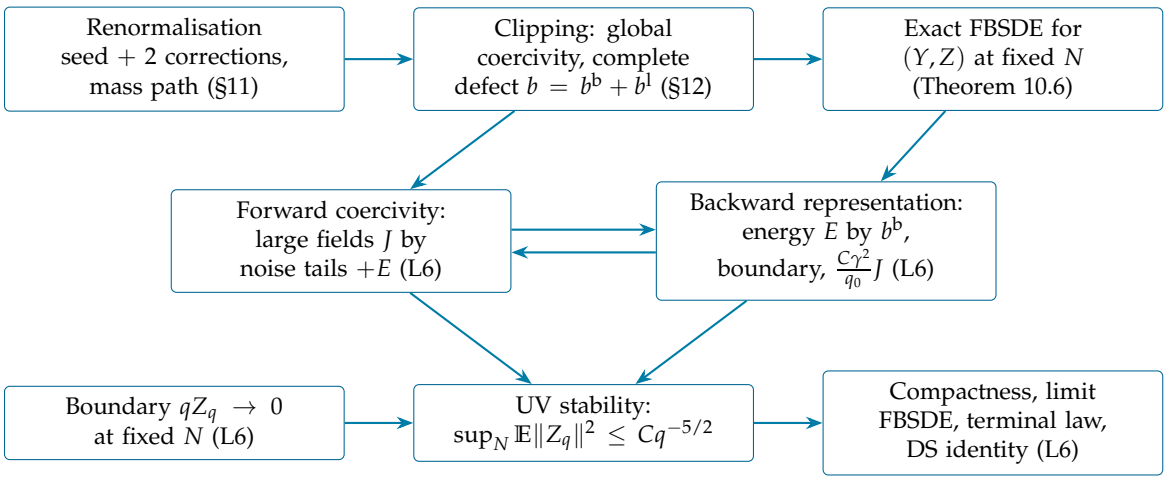


Figure 10.1. The structure of the construction. The two arrows between the forward and backward estimates form the closed loop of Lecture 6: neither estimate closes on its own.

Exercises

Exercise 10.1. (Same Γ) Show that Γ_q of (10.11) coincides, up to a constant, with the Γ_t of (8.11) for the profile (10.2), and that $\Gamma_q + \frac{1}{2}\langle y, K_{q_0} y\rangle$ is the effective average action Γ^{EAA} of Theorem 8.4. Check that (10.13) agrees with (8.12).

Exercise 10.2. **(Gaussian case)** Let $V_N(\varphi)=\frac{a}{2}\|\varphi\|^2$, $a>0$. Compute $\mathcal{K}_q$, ψ_q, Cov_q and Γ_q explicitly, and check Proposition 10.4 and (10.13). Compare with Exercise 7.1.

Exercise 10.3. **(Bayes for the whole path)** Prove Proposition 10.3(a) for the whole observed path, not only for its value at q: show that P_q is a sufficient statistic.

Exercise 10.4. **(One site)** Take $N=1$ (one site, $\Delta=0$, $K_q=q$) and $\bar\Gamma_q(y)=\frac{\lambda}{4}y^4$. (a) Show that Y_q is the real root of $qY+\lambda Y^3=P_q$, and that $H_q(y)=(q+\gamma y^2)^{-1}$. Explain how large fields suppress the noise of Y. (b) Compute the defect $e_q(y)=-\frac12[(q+\gamma y^2)^{-1}-q^{-1}]$ and the drift $b_q(y)=-\gamma y\,(q+\gamma y^2)^{-3}$. Show that $|b_q(y)|\le\gamma q^{-3}|y|$, and compare with Proposition 12.2: on one site $a_2(q)=q^{-2}$ instead of $q^{-1/2}$, and no renormalisation is needed.

11 Renormalisation: why two of them

We now construct $\bar\Gamma_q$ on bounded fields. This section is deterministic: it uses no information on ν_N.

11.1 Scales and power counting

Two scales govern everything:

$$g_q:=\gamma q^{-1/2},\qquad r_q:=(q/\gamma)^{1/2},\qquad \gamma r_q^2=q. \tag{11.1}$$

g_q is the dimensionless coupling at resolution q: in $d=3$ the coupling λ has dimension of mass, and $q^{1/2}$ is the mass of the regulator. It is small at all scales if $g_{q_0}=\gamma q_0^{-1/2}$ is small; this is where the large mass enters. r_q is the field size at which the nonlinearity is comparable to the regulator: $D^2U(y)=\gamma y^2\approx q$ when $|y|\approx r_q$. Compare with the size of the free field at resolution q: $\mathrm{Var}X_q(x)=\int_{q_0}^q a_2\le Cq^{1/2}$, so typical fields have size $q^{1/4}=g_q^{1/2}r_q\ll r_q$.

We measure a k-tensor $T(x_1,\dots,x_k)$ (a kernel of a kth field derivative, a *vertex*) by its *rooted norm*

$$s(T)=\max_i\sup_{x_i}\int|T(x_1,\dots,x_k)|\prod_{j\neq i}\mathrm{d}x_j,$$

and a functional f by $\mathsf{S}_k(f)=\sup_{y\in\mathcal{B}_q}s\,(D^kf(y))$ on the *field ball*

$$\mathcal{B}_q:=\{y\in H_N:\|y\|_\infty<2r_q\}.$$

The natural size of the kth vertex of the loop corrections $\Gamma_q-U-\frac12\langle y,M_qy\rangle$ to the bare action is

$$\mathsf{S}_k\lesssim g_q\;q\;r_q^{2-k}. \tag{11.2}$$

For $k=2$ this says the Hessian of the corrections is g_q times the regulator q (while $D^2U\approx q$ at $|y|\approx r_q$); each extra field derivative costs r_q^{-1}. For $k=4$, $g_q\,q\,r_q^{-2}=\gamma g_q$: the quartic vertex of the corrections is γ times the small coupling. The whole construction is a bookkeeping of (11.2).

The basic loop estimate. Derivatives of $\frac12\mathrm{Tr}(K+D^2\Gamma)^{-1}$ are traces of closed chains $H\,D^{j_1+2}\Gamma\,H\cdots D^{j_p+2}\Gamma\,H$. A closed loop with p vertices, each carrying at least one external leg (vertices without external legs are resummed into H), and $p+1$ propagators H (two of them adjacent, H^2, once the trace is closed) is estimated by rooting one external slot, using two propagators in L^2 (each row has L^2 norm $\le(a_2)^{1/2}$) and the others in operator norm ($\le C/q$):

$$s(\mathrm{loop})\le C\;a_2(q)\;q^{-(p-1)}\prod_{i=1}^p s(T_i) \tag{11.3}$$

[FBSDE26]. The vertices of the bare action have $s(D^{j+2}U) \le C q r_q^{-j}$ on the ball ($D^3U = 2\gamma y$, $D^4U = 2\gamma$). With $a_2 \le C q^{-1/2}$, a loop with k external legs built from them is $\le C q^{1/2} r_q^{-k}$, and after the integration in q that produces Γ (which gains a factor q) it has size $q^{3/2} r_q^{-k} = g_q q r_q^{2-k}$: this is the origin of (11.2), the size of one loop. Replacing a bare vertex by a vertex of a correction of relative size ε multiplies the loop by ε (Exercise 11.1). *Every further loop gains one power of g_q.*

11.2 The seed: one loop

The first approximation is the one-loop formula of Exercise 8.7(b): replace $D^2\Gamma$ by $D^2U = \gamma y^2$ in the Wetterich equation and integrate from $q = \infty$. With the quadratic part subtracted this gives the *seed*

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{L}_q(y) &= \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}[\log(I + C_q^{1/2}\gamma y^2 C_q^{1/2}) - C_q^{1/2}\gamma y^2 C_q^{1/2}], \\ \partial_q \mathcal{L}_q(y) &= \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}[G_q(y) - C_q] + \tfrac{\gamma}{2} a_2(q)\|y\|_2^2, \end{aligned} \tag{11.4}$$

with $G_q(y) = (K_q + \gamma y^2)^{-1}$. $\mathcal{L}_q \le 0$, and its constant and quadratic Taylor coefficients at $y = 0$ vanish. Its expansion in powers of the field,

$$\mathcal{L}_q(y) = \sum_{j \ge 2} \frac{(-1)^{j+1}}{2j} \mathrm{Tr}(C_q \gamma y^2)^j,$$

is the sum of one-loop diagrams with $2j$ external legs. The quartic term is the bubble $-\frac{\gamma^2}{4}\iint C_q(x,z)^2 y(x)^2 y(z)^2 \,\mathrm{d}x\,\mathrm{d}z$, with $s(D^4\mathcal{L}_q(0)) = 6\gamma^2 a_2(q) \le C g_q q r_q^{-2}$, as predicted by (11.2).

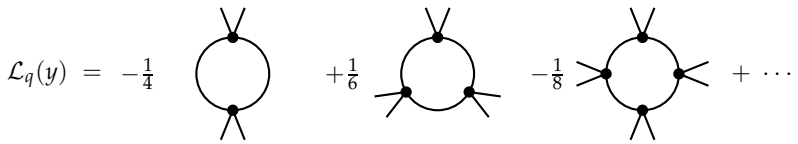


Figure 11.1. The seed (11.4) as one-loop graphs: lines C_q, and a vertex γy^2 with its two external fields at each corner. The j-th ring has $2j$ legs and coefficient $(-1)^{j+1}/(2j)$. The series sums to a logarithm and has radius of convergence r_q. The quartic ring is the bubble.

11.3 Corrections and the mass

The seed solves the Wetterich equation only with D^2U inside the trace. Its defect is of relative size g_q compared with the one-loop flow $q^{1/2} r_q^{-k}$ (two loops). To improve it, let $\Pi f(y) = f(y) - f(0) - \frac{1}{2} D^2 f(0)[y,y]$ remove the constant and quadratic Taylor coefficients (the *low jets*) of an even functional, let $M_q = \mu_q I + \Theta_q$ be a quadratic operator path (a running mass μ_q and an even, translation-invariant, centred kernel Θ_q, $\Theta_q 1 = 0$), and set

$$\mathcal{J}_q[M,h](y) := \tfrac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}[(K_q + M_q + D^2(U+h)(y))^{-1} - (K_q + M_q)^{-1}]. \tag{11.5}$$

The approximate action on the field ball is

$$\Gamma_q^{\circ}(y) = U(y) + \tfrac{1}{2}\langle y, M_q y\rangle + h_q^{[2]}(y), \tag{11.6}$$

with the nonlinear part built by two *integrated* Wetterich steps,

$$h^{[0]} = \mathcal{L}, \qquad h_q^{[j+1]} = \mathcal{L}_q - \int_q^\infty \Pi\,(\mathcal{J}_s[M, h^{[j]}] - \partial_s \mathcal{L}_s)\,\mathrm{d}s, \qquad j = 0, 1, \tag{11.7}$$

so that $\partial_q h^{[j+1]} = \Pi\,\mathcal{J}_q[M, h^{[j]}]$: each step inserts the previous approximation into the trace. The integrals run from ∞: the nonlinear part is fixed by the requirement that it vanishes at infinite resolution, where Γ_q must become the bare action (Theorem 8.4).

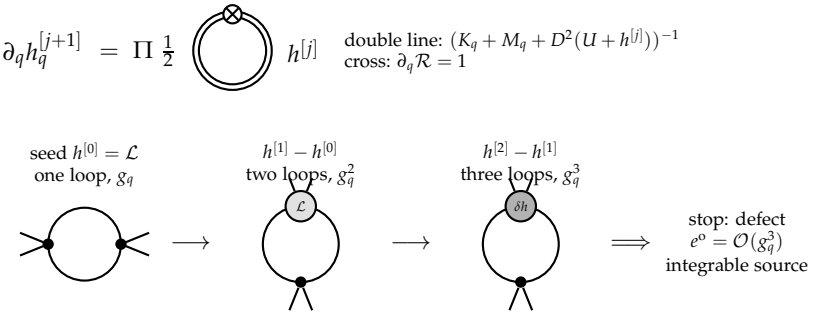


Figure 11.2. The iteration (11.7), schematically, with only two external legs drawn per vertex. Each step inserts the previous correction into the trace and gains one loop and one factor g_q, as in (11.11). After two steps the defect is the trace difference of order g_q^3, which gives (11.12) and makes the source integrable in the backward equation.

The quadratic part. The low jets are not iterated: they are handled exactly by the path M. The quadratic part of the flow at $y=0$ is, by evenness, $\frac{1}{2}D^2\mathrm{Tr}H(0) = -\frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Ctr}_{R_0^2}D^4\Gamma^{\mathrm{o}}(0)$, where $R_{0,q} = (K_q + M_q)^{-1}$ and $\mathrm{Ctr}_R T$ contracts two slots of T with the kernel R. Requiring that M solves this part of the flow exactly gives the *mass equation*

$$\partial_q M_q = B_q[M] := -\gamma \mathrm{Tr}(R_{0,q}^2)\, I - \frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Ctr}_{R_{0,q}^2} D^4 h_q^{[2]}(0), \tag{11.8}$$

(the source $B_q[M]$ is not the sampling Brownian motion B), with the *mixed boundary conditions*

$$\mu_{q_0} = 0, \qquad \Theta_q \to 0 \text{ as } q \to \infty$$

(the latter in first spatial moment). The running mass is pinned at the physical scale q_0, while the nonlocal kernel is pinned at infinity. The *bare mass* is then

$$\mu_N = \lim_{q\to\infty} \mu_q = \int_{q_0}^{\infty} \beta_q \,\mathrm{d}q, \qquad B_q 1 = \beta_q 1, \tag{11.9}$$

and it is this number that enters the Gibbs measure (10.4). Note the order: the counterterm is an output of the deterministic flow, not an input.

Proposition 11.1. (The coefficient construction [FBSDE26]) *For q_0 large enough (depending on γ, not on N), the system (11.7)–(11.8) has a unique solution in a ball, with*

$$|\mu_q| \le C\gamma\sqrt{q}, \qquad v_1(\Theta_q) \le C\gamma^2 q^{-1/2}, \qquad \|\partial_q M_q\|_{\mathrm{row}} \le C g_q, \tag{11.10}$$

where $v_1(\Theta) = \int d(0,z)\,|\Theta(0,z)|\mathrm{d}z$. The seed obeys $\mathcal{N}_{k,q}(\mathcal{L}) \le C_k g_q q r_q^{2-k}$, $4 \le k \le 10$, and the corrections obey

$$\mathcal{N}_{k,q}(h^{[j]} - h^{[j-1]}) \le C_k\, g_q^{j+1}\, q\, r_q^{2-k}, \qquad 4 \le k \le 10 - 2j, \quad j = 1,2, \tag{11.11}$$

where $\mathcal{N}_{k,q}(f) = \mathsf{S}_k(f) + \sqrt{q}\; v_1(D^k f(0))$, and for a k-tensor

$$v_1(T) = \max_{i,a<b} \sup_{x_i} \int d(x_a, x_b)|T| \prod_{j\neq i} \mathrm{d}x_j.$$

The complete defect of Γ^{o} on the ball is $e_q^{\mathrm{o}} = \Pi\,(\mathcal{J}_q[M, h^{[1]}] - \mathcal{J}_q[M, h^{[2]}])$, and

$$\mathsf{S}_4(e_q^{\mathrm{o}}) \le C\gamma^5 q^{-3}. \tag{11.12}$$

At fixed N the bare mass exists, $|\mu_N| \lesssim \gamma \mathrm{Tr}C \lesssim \gamma N$, and $|\mu_N - \mu_q| \le C\gamma N^3/q$, $\|\Theta_q\|_{\mathrm{row}} \le CN\gamma^2 q^{-1/2} \to 0$ as $q \to \infty$.

Idea of the proof. (a) *Trace Lipschitz estimate.* If two corrections $h, \hat{h}$ obey the individual bounds (11.2) up to order $k+2$ and their difference obeys them with g_q replaced by ε_q, then $\mathcal{N}_k(\mathcal{J}[M,h]-\mathcal{J}[M,\hat{h}]) \le C\,\varepsilon_q\, q^{1/2} r_q^{-k}$. Expand D^k of the trace into loops; in each, telescope the difference onto one marked vertex or propagator and apply (11.3). (b) *Integration.* Each step gains one g; the integrand of (11.7) is $O(\gamma^{1+k/2} s^{-k/2})$ in the kth derivative, and that of the increment $h^{[j+1]}-h^{[j]}$ is $O(\gamma^{1+k/2} s^{-k/2} g_s^j)$, integrable at $s=\infty$ for $k \ge 4$. The low jets have been removed, so the lower derivatives are controlled by Taylor's formula from the fourth. (c) *Mass path.* Given M in the ball, the right side of (11.8) is computed from the corrections, and the map $M \mapsto (\mu, \Theta)$ is a contraction for large q_0: differences gain a factor g_{q_0} (for μ after integrating from q_0, using $\sup_x \log x/\sqrt{x} < \infty$). (d) *Defect.* The mass equation supplies exactly the quadratic jet of the flow, and $\partial_q h^{[2]} = \Pi\,\mathcal{J}[M, h^{[1]}]$, so the defect is the trace difference between the last two approximations, of order g^3: by (a) with $\varepsilon_q = g_q^3$, $\mathsf{S}_4(e^{\mathrm{o}}) \le C g_q^3 q^{1/2} r_q^{-4} = C\gamma^5 q^{-3}$. □

Two technical points are hidden in this sketch. First, the trace estimate (a) needs more derivatives than it controls: the kth derivative of the trace involves vertices of order $k+2$. Ten derivatives of the seed leave eight after one step and six after two; this is why the number of steps must be finite and fixed in advance (an infinite iteration loses all derivatives). Second, the quadratic kernel Θ_q must be measured in a first spatial moment v_1, not in a second one: the estimate $\|\delta_z^2 C_q\|_{\mathrm{row}} \lesssim d(0,z)^2$, which a second moment would require, fails by a logarithm, and one uses $\|\delta_z^2 C_q\|_{\mathrm{row}} \lesssim q^{-1/2} d(0,z)$ instead [FBSDE26]. This is also why $\mathcal{N}_k$ contains a spatial moment at $y=0$.

11.4 Two mass renormalisations

The bare mass μ_N diverges as $N \to \infty$. Its two divergent parts are the two divergent self-energy diagrams of Appendix A.2 of Lecture 4.

- *The tadpole.* The first term of (11.8) integrates to $-\gamma \int_{q_0}^{\infty} \mathrm{Tr} R_{0,q}^2\, \mathrm{d}q \approx -\gamma \mathrm{Tr} C = -3\lambda \mathrm{Tr} C \sim -N$. This is Wick ordering: $\frac{\lambda}{4}\varphi^4 - \frac{3}{2}\lambda c \varphi^2$ agrees, up to a constant, with $\frac{\lambda}{4} H_4(\varphi; c)$, with $c = C(x,x)$ ((A.5) of Lecture 4).
- *The sunset.* The second term contracts the bubble contained in $D^4 h^{[2]}(0)$ (the quartic coefficient of the seed) with R_0^2, and integrating in q produces the two-loop self-energy, which diverges like $\lambda^2 \int_{|z|>1/N} |z|^{-3} \mathrm{d}z \sim \lambda^2 \log N$. This is the sunset counterterm $\gamma_T \sim \log T$ of (A.7) of Lecture 4: with $\lambda_{\mathrm{L3}} = \lambda/4$ and $\gamma_T \int H_2 = \gamma_T \int \varphi^2 + \mathrm{const}$, the sunset part of μ_N is $2\gamma_T = 6\lambda^2 \int C^3 \approx \frac{3\lambda^2}{8\pi^2} \log N$, positive. (The double-tadpole logarithms in the two terms of (11.8), the bubble with a tadpole insertion and the mass insertion in $\mathrm{Tr} R_{0,q}^2$, cancel each other.)

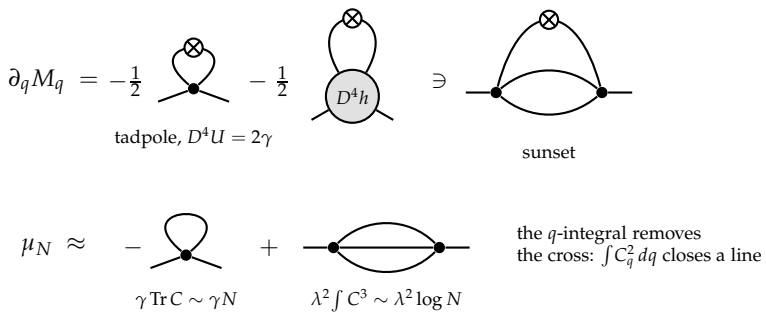


Figure 11.3. The mass equation (11.8) and the two divergent parts of the bare mass. The cross is the insertion $R_{0,q}^2$. Since $D^4 h^{[2]}(0)$ contains the bubble of Figure 11.1, its contraction contains the sunset. Integrating in q turns the crossed line into a line C: the tadpole is linear in N and the sunset logarithmic.

Power counting (Exercise A.3 of Lecture 4) says that no other counterterm is needed. In the flow this is the statement that the integrals (11.7) of all vertices with $k \geq 4$ legs converge at $q = \infty$: only the quadratic jet must be fixed by a boundary condition.

There is a subtlety: the running mass μ_q at fixed q has a limit as $N \to \infty$, but $\mu_N = \mu_\infty$ does not. One never interchanges these two limits. Also, the *whole* running kernel Θ_q is kept: replacing the sunset by its local part would leave a nonlocal remainder of the wrong size.

11.5 Two correction steps

Why two corrections, and not one or three? The answer is in the backward equation of (10.16). Freeze the noise and the large fields, and estimate the size of Z produced by a defect on the ball. The propagator of $\mathrm{d}Z = -H\,Z\,\mathrm{d}q + \dots$ from q to s is about s/q (since $H \approx C_q$ has norm q^{-1}), so

$$Z_q \approx \int_q^\infty \frac{s}{q}\, b_s\, \mathrm{d}s, \qquad |b_s| \lesssim \|H_s\|\, \mathsf{S}_4(e_s)\; r_s^3 \lesssim s^{-1} \mathsf{S}_4(e_s)\; r_s^3, \tag{11.13}$$

where we used that the low jets of e vanish, so on the ball $|De| \leq \mathsf{S}_4(e)|y|^3/6$. After n correction steps the defect is the trace difference of the last two approximations, of relative size g^{n+1}: by the trace estimate,

$$\mathsf{S}_4(e_s) \lesssim g_s^{n+1} s^{1/2} r_s^{-4} = \gamma^{n+3} s^{-(n+4)/2}, \qquad |b_s| \lesssim \gamma^{n+3/2} s^{-(n+3)/2},$$

and therefore

$$|Z_q| \lesssim \frac{\gamma^{n+3/2}}{q} \int_q^\infty s^{-(n+1)/2} \mathrm{d}s.$$

steps n	$\mathsf{S}_4(e_s)$	$\lvert b_s\rvert$	$\int_q^\infty \frac{s}{q}\lvert b_s\rvert \mathrm{d}s$
0 (seed only)	$\gamma^3 s^{-2}$	$\gamma^{3/2} s^{-3/2}$	∞ (power)
1	$\gamma^4 s^{-5/2}$	$\gamma^{5/2} s^{-2}$	∞ (logarithm)
2	$\gamma^5 s^{-3}$	$\gamma^{7/2} s^{-5/2}$	$2\gamma^{7/2} q^{-3/2}$

With one step the bounded-field source produces a logarithmically divergent error; two steps are the minimum, and they suffice: $Z_q^{\mathrm{b}} = O(q^{-3/2})$, and the backward energy $\gamma^{-1} \int q^{1/2} |Z^{\mathrm{b}}|^2 \mathrm{d}q$ is finite (Lecture 6). The general (fractional) theory gives the depth criterion $(n+2)\,\varkappa > (3+\varkappa)/2$, with subcriticality $\varkappa = \frac{1}{2}$ for Φ^4_3: $(2+2)\cdot\frac{1}{2} = 2 > \frac{7}{4}$, while $n = 1$ gives $\frac{3}{2} < \frac{7}{4}$. This is a sufficient condition, which loses $\varkappa/2$; for Φ^4_3 the heuristic above shows that $n > 1$ suffices, with $n = 1$ borderline.

The two senses of "two renormalisations" are related. The mass counterterm must contain the sunset because the quartic vertex of the corrections, already of the seed, contains the bubble, and contracting it produces the sunset; and the second step is needed because the defect of the first one, the three-loop remainder, is borderline in the backward equation, exactly as the sunset is borderline in the mass.

Exercises

Exercise 11.1. (**Counting loops**) (a) Use (11.3) to show that a loop with p vertices $D^{j_i+2}(U+h)$, $j_i \geq 1$, each with $s \leq C q r_q^{-j_i}$, and $k = \sum j_i$ external legs has rooted norm $\leq C a_2(q)\; q\; r_q^{-k} \leq C q^{1/2} r_q^{-k}$. (b) Show that $q \cdot q^{1/2} r_q^{-k} = g_q\, q\, r_q^{2-k}$. (c) If one vertex is replaced by a vertex of size $\varepsilon\; q\, r_q^{-j}$, show that the loop gains the factor ε. Deduce the sizes g^{j+1} of the increments in (11.11).

Exercise 11.2. (**The bubble**) Compute $D^4 \mathcal{L}_q(0)$. Show that its rooted norm is $6\gamma^2 a_2(q)$ and its first spatial moment is $O(\gamma^2 q^{-1})$.

Exercise 11.3. (**Small Hessians are not enough**) On one site take $q = \gamma = 1$, $M = 0$, fixed small $\alpha, \delta > 0$, $\hat{h}_n(y) = \alpha\, n^{-2}(\cos(n\,y) - 1 + n^2 y^2/2)$, $h_n = \hat{h}_n + \frac{\delta}{12} y^4$. Show that both have small Hessians on $|y| < 2$, that $h_n - \hat{h}_n$ has bounded derivatives, but $D^4(\mathcal{T}[h_n] - \mathcal{T}[\hat{h}_n])(0) = 12\,(2\,\delta + \alpha\,\delta\, n^2 + \delta^2)$ is unbounded in n. Conclude that the trace estimate needs the individual higher derivative bounds.

Exercise 11.4. (**Why two steps**) Verify the table above. With one step, show that the bounded-field part of Z is of size $q^{-1} \log(T/q)$ on $[q, T]$, for an upper scale cutoff T.

12 The flow at large fields

12.1 The large-field problem

All the estimates of Proposition 11.1 hold on the field ball $\|y\|_\infty < 2r_q$, and only there. But the forecast Y_q is a random field on N^3 sites, and nothing prevents it from being larger than r_q somewhere. The free field has typical size $q^{1/4} \ll r_q$, but it exceeds r_q with small, nonzero probability, and nothing a priori controls the interacting forecast. We need an action $\bar\Gamma_q$ defined and *uniformly convex for all fields*, which agrees with Γ_q^{o} on the ball.

A scalar model. The difficulty is already visible in the one-site seed, $\mathcal{L}_q(y) = \frac{1}{2}[\log(1+\gamma y^2/q) - \gamma y^2/q]$. Its power series $\sum_{j\ge 2} \frac{(-1)^{j+1}}{2j} (\gamma y^2/q)^j$ has radius of convergence exactly r_q: the singularities are at $y = \pm i r_q$. Truncating it at any order produces a polynomial whose top coefficient has sign $(-1)^{j+1}$: for even $j \ge 4$ the truncation is unbounded below and destroys the convexity of $U + \mathcal{L}$ at $|y| \gg r_q$. The exact function is harmless: its logarithmic part grows only logarithmically, and $|\mathcal{L}_q''(y)| \le \frac{9}{8}\gamma/q \le 2\gamma/q$ for all y. In field theory we do not have the exact function, only bounds on the ball, obtained through an expansion of the trace in vertices (the corrections are not polynomials, but their estimates are expansions in the field). This is the *large-field problem*: perturbative control holds for $|y| \lesssim r_q$, and outside one needs a non-perturbative replacement that preserves the structure the estimates use.

The structure to preserve is coercivity, and it is carried by the bare quartic term. In the scalar model the coordinate equation $qy + \lambda y^3 = p$ has noise coefficient

$$H_q(y) = \frac{1}{q+\gamma y^2} \le \frac{1}{q} \wedge \frac{1}{\gamma y^2}:$$

large fields are *more* elliptic and less noisy. A good large-field extension keeps U untouched and freezes only the correction.

12.2 Clipping

Let $\tau\colon \mathbb{R} \to \mathbb{R}$ be smooth and odd, $\tau(u) = u$ on $[-1,1]$, constant outside $[-2,2]$, with $0 \le \tau' \le 1$, and set

$$\kappa_q(y)(x) := r_q\, \tau(y(x)/r_q), \qquad \tilde h_q := h_q^{[2]} \circ \kappa_q, \qquad \bar\Gamma_q := U + \tfrac{1}{2}\langle y, M_q y\rangle + \tilde h_q. \tag{12.1}$$

The clip acts pointwise in space and maps every field into the ball. The quartic and quadratic parts are not clipped. By the chain rule, with factors $|\kappa_q^{(b)}| \le C r_q^{1-b}$, the clipped correction obeys the same bounds (11.2) *globally*:

$$s(D^j \tilde h_q) \le C g_q q r_q^{2-j}\ (j = 2,3,4), \qquad s(D^2 \partial_q \tilde h_q) \le C g_q, \tag{12.2}$$

for all $y \in H_N$; the scale derivative includes the motion of the clip, $\partial_q \kappa_q = O(r_q/q)$.

Lemma 12.1. (Global coercivity) *For q_0 large, for all $y \in H_N$ and $q \ge q_0$,*

$$c\,(K_q + \gamma y^2) \le H_q(y)^{-1} \le C\,(K_q + \gamma y^2),$$
$$\|H_q(y)\|_{p\to p} \le \frac{1 + C(g_q + g_q^2)}{q} \quad (1 \le p \le \infty), \qquad \operatorname{diag} H_q(y)^2 \le C a_2(q). \tag{12.3}$$

Idea. $H^{-1} = K_q + \gamma y^2 + M_q + D^2\tilde h_q$, and $M_q + D^2\tilde h_q$ is small relative to K_q: $\|D^2\tilde h_q\| \le C g_q q$, and M_q is small after multiplication by C_q (the centred kernel is controlled by its first moment, Exercise 12.1). Write $H = (I + G(M + D^2\tilde h))^{-1} G$ with $G = (K_q + \gamma y^2)^{-1}$ and use the Neumann series and Lemma 10.1. □

So $\bar{\Gamma}_q$ is a globally convex action, and Theorem 10.6 applies.

12.3 The complete defect

On the set $\{\|y\|_\infty \le r_q\}$ the clip is the identity and the defect is e^{o}, of size (11.12). Outside it, the clipped action does not solve the Wetterich equation even approximately in relative terms. Split the drift into its bounded-field and large-field parts,

$$b_q^{\mathrm{b}}(y) := -H_q(y)\; D\kappa_q(y)\; De_q^{\mathrm{o}}(\kappa_q y), \qquad b_q^{\mathrm{l}} := b_q - b_q^{\mathrm{b}},$$

and let $\chi_q(y) = 1_{|y|>r_q}$ (pointwise) and $t_q(y) = y\,\chi_q(y)$, the field restricted to the large-field set.

Proposition 12.2. (Complete source bounds [FBSDE26]) *Uniformly in $y \in H_N$, N and $p \in [1, \infty]$,*

$$\begin{aligned} &\|b_q^{\mathrm{b}}(y)\|_p \le C\gamma^{7/2} q^{-5/2}, \\ &\|b_q^{\mathrm{l}}(y)\|_p \le C\gamma q^{-3/2}(\|t_q\|_p + r_q^{-1}\|y^2\chi_q\|_p), \\ &\|b_q^{\mathrm{l}}(y)\|_2^2 \le C\gamma^4 q^{-5}\|t_q\|_6^6. \end{aligned} \tag{12.4}$$

Moreover $\|b_q(y)\|_p \le C\gamma q^{-3/2}\|y\|_p$.

The first bound is (11.13) with $n=2$: on the ball $|De^{\mathrm{o}}| \le \mathsf{S}_4(e^{\mathrm{o}})\,(2r)^3/6$, and $q^{-1}\gamma^5 q^{-3} r_q^3 = \gamma^{7/2} q^{-5/2}$. The large-field part is as large as the bound $\gamma q^{-3/2}|y| = (g_q/q)|y|$ on the whole drift (no smallness beyond the factor g_q already present in b), but it is *supported on the large-field set* (up to nonlocal tails controlled by operator bounds). The last bound follows from the second since on $\{|y|>r\}$, $|t| + r^{-1}y^2 \le 2r^{-2}|t|^3$, and $(\gamma q^{-3/2} r^{-2})^2 = \gamma^4 q^{-5}$.

Where the large-field error comes from. Compute the gradient of the defect of the clipped action and compare it with $D\kappa\, De^{\mathrm{o}}(\kappa y)$. With $z = \kappa_q(y)$, $J = D\kappa_q(y)$ (multiplication by $\tau'(y/r)$), $h = h_q^{[2]}$, $M' = \partial_q M_q$, and the unclipped response $H^{\mathrm{o}} = (K + M + \gamma z^2 + D^2 h(z))^{-1}$, the difference has four groups (seven terms):

i. the mass term $M'y - JM'z$: the quadratic part is not clipped, but its flow was computed at z;

ii. the motion of the clip, $JD^2h(z)\,\partial_q\kappa + (D\partial_q\kappa)^* Dh(z)$;

iii. $\gamma(y - Jz)\mathrm{diag}H^2$ and $\gamma Jz\,\mathrm{diag}(H^2 - (H^{\mathrm{o}})^2)$: the quartic vertex sees y, the correction sees z, and the two responses differ by $\gamma(y^2 - z^2)$ and by the chain-rule terms of the clipped Hessian, all supported on $\{|y| > r_q\}$;

iv. the contraction of $D^3(h\circ\kappa) - JD^3h(z)$ (the chain rule produces terms with κ'', κ''', supported on large fields) and of D^3h with $H^2 - (H^{\mathrm{o}})^2$.

Each group vanishes if $\|y\|_\infty \le r_q$, and each is bounded by g_q times $|t|$ or $r^{-1}y^2\chi$, in L^p, by the same loop estimates ([FBSDE26]; Exercise 12.2 for the one-site version). There is no cancellation to exploit: the clipping error is genuinely of the size $(g_q/q)|y|$ of the whole drift on the large-field set. What saves us is that this set is rarely visited, and its occupation is controlled by the coercivity of the actual dynamics. Lecture 6 proves exactly this, with the weighted *large-field action*

$$\int_{q_0}^{\infty} q^{-3/2}\,\gamma\|t_q(Y_q)\|_6^6\,\mathrm{d}q,$$

(the t-part of the large-field action of Lecture 6), whose weight is matched to the last bound in (12.4): $q^{7/2}\cdot\gamma^4 q^{-5} = \gamma^3\cdot(\gamma q^{-3/2})$, so $\int q^{7/2}\|b_q^{\mathrm{l}}\|_2^2\mathrm{d}q \le C\gamma^3\int q^{-3/2}\gamma\|t_q\|_6^6\mathrm{d}q$, where $q^{7/2}$ is the weight with which $\|b^{\mathrm{l}}\|_2^2$ enters the backward representation (Lecture 6).

The coordinate correction. Finally, write the approximate coordinate equation as

$$K_q\Phi_q = K_q(Y_q + \varrho_q(Y_q)) + \tfrac{\gamma}{3}Y_q^3, \qquad \varrho_q(y) := C_q(M_q y + D\tilde{h}_q(y)), \tag{12.5}$$

using $DU(y) = \lambda y^3 = \frac{\gamma}{3}y^3$. The correction is a small contraction, $\|D\varrho_q(y)\|_{p\to p} \le \varepsilon_q := C(g_q + g_q^2)$, for all y and $1 \le p \le \infty$, and $\varrho_q(0) = 0$ by evenness. So, up to a small Lipschitz perturbation, *the forecast is the solution of the cubic elliptic equation* $K_q(Y+\varrho) + \frac{\gamma}{3}Y^3 = K_q\Phi_q$ *driven by the field at resolution* q. This is the equation whose coercivity Lecture 6 exploits.

12.4 Why the Polchinski expansion is not enough

Lecture 4 gives two exact descriptions of the flow: the Polchinski equation for the force F at the field Φ, and the Wetterich equation at the forecast ψ. We use the second, here and in Lecture 6. The first looks more economical, and the following programme is natural. Keep the bare cube $-\lambda\varphi^3$ unclipped, so that the approximate force stays coercive at all fields. Expand the rest of the force in perturbation theory and clip only these higher orders. Pay for the clipping in the source of the equation for the remainder $R = F - f$, using the a priori estimates. No Legendre transform would be needed.

Here we test the programme where everything can be computed: on one site. There is no spatial structure and no renormalisation, so whatever goes wrong has nothing to do with divergences. The result is that a frozen cube is the wrong approximation at large fields: the remainder must contain a cube of its own, and it cancels the coercivity that the programme relies on. The cure is to integrate the cube, that is, to solve the transport part of the flow exactly. This produces a global approximation with a uniformly small error, and it is precisely the forecast coordinate of Section 10.5.

Conventions. As in Exercise 10.4: $N = 1$, $\Delta = 0$, $K_q = q$, $V(\varphi) = \frac{\lambda}{4}\varphi^4$, $\gamma = 3\lambda$ and $r_q = (q/\gamma)^{1/2}$. We write $S = C_q = 1/q$ for the remaining covariance, and x for the value of the field at resolution q.

The exact force is linear at large fields. The effective potential and the force are

$$V_q(x) = -\log \mathbb{E}\exp(-\frac{\lambda}{4}(x + S^{1/2}\xi)^4), \quad F_q = -V_q',$$

with ξ a standard Gaussian, and they solve the Polchinski and Burgers equations

$$\partial_q V + \frac{1}{2}S^2V'' = \frac{1}{2}S^2(V')^2, \quad \partial_q F + \frac{1}{2}S^2F'' + S^2FF' = 0. \tag{12.6}$$

Let $\mathbb{E}_x$ be the expectation for the probability density proportional to $\exp(-\frac{\lambda}{4}y^4 - \frac{q}{2}(y-x)^2)$, and $m_q(x) = \mathbb{E}_x Y$. Differentiating V_q, and integrating by parts in y, gives

$$F_q(x) = -\lambda\,\mathbb{E}_x Y^3 = q(m_q(x) - x). \tag{12.7}$$

This is (10.9): the posterior mean is the forecast, $\psi_q = m_q(\Phi_q)$. So F_q measures how far the forecast lies behind the field.

Lemma 12.3. (Posterior mean) *For all* x *and* q, $|m_q(x)| \le 2\lambda^{-1/4} + 2(q|x|/\lambda)^{1/3}$.

Proof. Integrating the derivative of y times the density gives $\lambda\mathbb{E}_x Y^4 + q\mathbb{E}_x Y^2 - q\,x\mathbb{E}_x Y = 1$. With $M = (\mathbb{E}_x Y^4)^{1/4}$ this gives $\lambda M^4 \le 1 + q|x|M$, and Young's inequality gives $\frac{\lambda}{2}M^4 \le 1 + (q|x|)^{4/3}(2\lambda)^{-1/3}$. Finally $|m_q| \le M$. □

Therefore, by (12.7), the two regimes of the force are

$$F_q(x) \to -\lambda x^3 \quad (\text{fixed } x, q\to\infty), \qquad F_q(x) = -q\,x + O(|x|^{1/3}) \quad (\text{fixed } q, |x|\to\infty). \tag{12.8}$$

The limits cannot be interchanged. The crossover is at $|x| \sim r_q$, where the cube equals the Gaussian restoring force: $\lambda r_q^3 \sim q\, r_q$. Beyond it the force is linear, because convolution with a Gaussian of variance S cannot produce a force steeper than x/S.

Proposition 12.4. (The remainder of a frozen cube) *Let $f(x) = -\lambda x^3 + f_1(x)$ with $f_1(x) = o(|x|^3)$, for instance linear terms plus bounded clipped corrections. At every fixed q, the remainder $R_q = F_q - f$ satisfies*

$$\frac{R_q(x)}{\lambda x^3} \to 1 \quad (|x| \to \infty).$$

So no estimate can make R a small fraction of the retained cube uniformly in the field. The cube in R is not a new counterterm, since there is nothing to renormalise here. It is the compensation for having frozen the leading term of a force that does not stay cubic.

The field equation does not see the cube. The field equation (18.5) of Lecture 6 on one site is $q_0 \Phi_q = J_q F_q(\Phi_q) + \eta_q$, where $J_q = (q - q_0)/q$. Its noise is the filtered measurement noise, so $\mathbb{E}\exp(h\eta_q) \le \exp((q-q_0)h^2/2)$ whatever the interaction (Lemma 13.2 of Lecture 6). With the frozen cube $f = -\lambda x^3$ the equation looks coercive:

$$q_0 x + J_q \lambda x^3 = J_q R_q(x) + \eta_q(x).$$

But by Proposition 12.4, $J_q R_q$ cancels the cube on the left side at large fields. Inserting (12.7) shows what is left:

$$q\, x = (q - q_0) m_q(x) + \eta_q(x). \tag{12.9}$$

There is still confinement, but it is linear, and it comes from the sublinear growth of m_q.

Proposition 12.5. (Tails on one site) *If $q^2 \ge 24\lambda$, then $|m_q(x)| \le \frac{9}{10}|x|$ for $|x| \ge r_q$, and for $R \ge r_q$*

$$\mathbb{P}(|\Phi_q| \ge R) \le 2\exp\Big(-\frac{q^2 R^2}{200(q-q_0)}\Big).$$

Proof. The mean m has the sign of x, the density being an even density tilted by e^{qxy}. Jensen's inequality in the identity of Lemma 12.3 gives $\lambda m^4 + q m^2 - q\, x\, m \le 1$. If $x \ge r_q$ and $m > \frac{9}{10}x$, then $\lambda m^3 + q(m - x) > x(\frac{729}{1000}\lambda x^2 - \frac{q}{10}) \ge \frac{143}{1000} q\, x$, as $\lambda x^2 \ge q/3$, so the left side is at least $\frac{1287}{10000} q\, x^2 \ge \frac{429}{10000} q^2/\lambda > 1$, a contradiction. So $|\eta_q(x)| \ge \frac{q}{10}|x|$ by (12.9), and we conclude with the sub-Gaussian bound. □

At $R = r_q$ the exponent is at least $q^2/(600\lambda)$. This estimate treats the combined restoring force through the posterior moment. It never uses the cube as a coercive term against a remainder regarded as a source.

Remark 12.6. (This does not transfer to the lattice) With a quadratic term $\frac{r}{2}y^2$ in the action, Lemma 12.3 acquires the term $((q+r)_-/\lambda)^{1/2}$. On the lattice the bare mass makes r divergent and negative, so this elementary moment bound is not uniform until the renormalised cancellations have been built in. The scalar tail bound is therefore not an independent input for the field theory.

What clipping does to the Polchinski equation. For a potential U put $D_q = \partial_q + \frac{1}{2}S^2\partial_x^2$, $B(U, U) = \frac{1}{2}S^2(U')^2$ and $\mathcal{E}_q(U) = D_q U - B(U, U)$. So $\mathcal{E}_q(V_q) = 0$, and the force $f = -U'$ has Burgers defect $E = \partial_q f + \frac{1}{2}S^2 f'' + S^2 f f' = -\partial_x \mathcal{E}_q(U)$. Perturbation theory solves

$$D_q U_1 = 0, \quad D_q U_2 = B(U_1, U_1),$$

with $U_1=\frac{\lambda}{4}(x^4+6Sx^2+3S^2)$, whose leading term is the cube in the force, and $U_2=-\frac{1}{2}\lambda^2 S x^6+\dots$, the first tree. Keep U_1 unclipped and clip the correction: $U^c=U_1+U_2\circ\kappa_q$, with the clip κ_q of (12.1). Writing $CU_2=U_2\circ\kappa_q$, a direct expansion gives the exact identity

$$\mathcal{E}_q(U^c)=(C-1)B(U_1,U_1)+[D_q,C]U_2-2B(U_1,CU_2)-B(CU_2,CU_2). \tag{12.10}$$

Without the clip only the last two terms, of higher order, would be present. The clip reintroduces a defect at exactly the order that U_2 was built to cancel. For $|x|\geq 2r_q$ the term CU_2 does not depend on x, so $\mathcal{E}_q(U^c)=c(q)-\frac{1}{2}S^2(U_1')^2$, and the force defect is exactly

$$E_q(x)=S^2U_1'(x)U_1''(x)=3\lambda^2S^2x^5(1+O(S/x^2)). \tag{12.11}$$

This is the price of the clipping. At the edge of the clip it has size $(q/\lambda)^{1/2}$, which is not integrable in q, so it can only be paid through the small probability of reaching the clip. Along the exact process $\mathrm{d}\Phi_q=S^2F_q(\Phi_q)\,\mathrm{d}q+S\,\mathrm{d}W_q$, Itô's formula gives for $R_q=F_q(\Phi_q)-f_q^c(\Phi_q)$ the equation

$$\mathrm{d}R_q=-[E_q(\Phi_q)+S^2(f_q^c)'(\Phi_q)R_q]\,\mathrm{d}q+\Xi_q\,\mathrm{d}W_q. \tag{12.12}$$

The transport term has a favourable sign at large fields: $(f^c)'=-3\lambda(x^2+S)$ for $|x|\geq 2r_q$, which is the dissipation one hopes to use (near the clip the sign fails: on the ball the quintic takes over beyond $|x|\approx 0.77r_q$). But at large fields the bracket is $3\lambda^2S^2x^5-3\lambda S^2x^2R$, and for the true $R\sim\lambda x^3$ the two terms cancel at leading order. The source and the dissipation are the same quantity, so estimating them separately gives nothing. To close, one would need, for instance, a signed estimate that retains this cancellation, or a tail bound for Φ obtained independently of R. On one site Proposition 12.5 is such a bound: the probability of reaching the clip is at most of order $\exp(-cq^2/\lambda)$, so in expectation the source is exponentially small, and the frozen cube is not ruled out there. But that bound comes from the posterior moment, and by the remark above it does not transfer. The field equation alone cannot replace it, since its restoring force is the cube and R together, which is what we are trying to estimate.

Going further in perturbation theory does not help: any finite depth of expansion leaves the same structure (Exercise 12.5), and we shall see in a moment that the series of trees stops converging inside r_q.

Integrating the cube. The term responsible for all this is the nonlinear transport in (12.6). So solve it exactly: let f_q solve the Burgers equation without diffusion,

$$\partial_q f+S^2ff'=0,\qquad f_\infty(x)=-\lambda x^3. \tag{12.13}$$

The characteristics give the solution in closed form.

Proposition 12.7. (The integrated cube) *For $x\in\mathbb{R}$, let $y=y_q(x)$ be the unique real root of $qy+\lambda y^3=qx$. Then the solution of (12.13) is*

$$f_q(x)=-\lambda y_q(x)^3=q(y_q(x)-x), \tag{12.14}$$

and it has the following properties.

- *a)* ***Variational form.*** *$y_q(x)$ is the minimiser of $\frac{\lambda}{4}y^4+\frac{q}{2}(y-x)^2$, and $f_q=-\bar V_q'$ for the minimum value $\bar V_q(x)$.*
- *b)* ***Small fields.*** *$f_q(x)=q\sum_{k\geq 1}(-\lambda/q)^k c_k x^{2k+1}$ with $c_k=\frac{1}{2k+1}\frac{(3k)!}{k!(2k)!}$, so $f_q=-\lambda x^3+3\lambda^2Sx^5-12\lambda^3S^2x^7+\dots$. This is the sum of the tree expansion. Its radius of convergence is $|x|=\frac{2}{3}r_q$.*
- *c)* ***Large fields.*** *$\lambda|y|^3\leq q|x|$, so $f_q(x)=-qx+O(|x|^{1/3})$ at fixed q, as for the exact force, and $f_q'=-\gamma y^2/(1+\gamma y^2/q)\leq 0$ for all x.*

d) ***Defect.*** *f_q fails to solve Burgers by the diffusion term alone, which is q times the drift of Exercise 10.4:*

$$E_q = \frac{1}{2} S^2 f_q''(x) = q\, b_q(y_q(x)), \quad b_q(y) = -\gamma y (q+\gamma y^2)^{-3}. \tag{12.15}$$

Proof. Differentiate $x = y + \lambda S y^3$ with $d = 1 + \gamma y^2/q$: $y' = 1/d$, $\partial_S y = -\lambda y^3/d$, $f' = -\gamma y^2/d$ and $f'' = -2\gamma y/d^3$. Hence $\partial_S f = \gamma\lambda y^5/d = ff'$, which is (12.13) as $\partial_q = -S^2\partial_S$. For (a), the stationarity condition is $\lambda y^3 + q(y-x) = 0$. For (b), use Lagrange inversion on $y = x - \lambda S y^3$; the nearest singularity is where $d = 0$, that is at $y = \pm \mathrm{i} r_q$, $x = \pm\frac{2}{3}\mathrm{i} r_q$. Finally (c) and (d) are read off from the formulas, since $d = 1/(qH_q(y))$ with $H_q(y) = (q+\gamma y^2)^{-1}$. □

Item (b) explains why the depth of the expansion is not the issue. The tree series has the same complex singularity $y = \pm \mathrm{i} r_q$ as the one-loop seed of Section 12.1, and its truncations at even k point outward at large fields.

The defect is now bounded for all fields, and it gives a global estimate.

Theorem 12.8. (Global error of the integrated cube) *Let $C_* = 3\sup_z |z|(1+3z^2)^{-3}$, so $C_* < \frac{1}{2}$. For all $q > 0$,*

$$\sup_{x\in\mathbb{R}} |F_q(x) - f_q(x)| \le 2C_*(\lambda/q)^{1/2}. \tag{12.16}$$

Proof. Use $S = 1/q$ as time, starting from $S = 0$. Subtracting, $\hat{R} = F - f$ solves the linear problem

$$\mathcal{D}\hat{R} = \frac{1}{2} f'', \quad \mathcal{D} = \partial_S - \frac{1}{2}\partial_x^2 - F\partial_x - f', \quad \hat{R}_0 = 0.$$

The zeroth-order coefficient has the good sign, as $-f' \ge 0$. With $z = (\lambda S)^{1/2} y$, the source obeys $\frac{1}{2}|f''| \le C_*(\lambda/S)^{1/2}$, which is integrable at $S = 0$, so $\beta(S) = 2C_*(\lambda S)^{1/2}$ satisfies $\mathcal{D}\beta \ge \frac{1}{2}|f''|$. To apply the maximum principle on the line, take $\chi = \mathrm{e}^{3S}(1+x^4)$. Then $\mathcal{D}\chi \ge 0$, since $6x^2 \le 3(1+x^4)$ and $xF(x) \le 0$; the last holds because $F = -\lambda \mathbb{E}_x Y^3$, and $\mathbb{E}_x Y^3$ has the sign of x, the density being an even density tilted by e^{qxy}. Both F and f grow at most cubically, uniformly for bounded S: $|f| \le \lambda|x|^3$ since $|y| \le |x|$, and $\lambda\mathbb{E}_x Y^6 + q\mathbb{E}_x Y^4 - qx\mathbb{E}_x Y^3 = 3\mathbb{E}_x Y^2$ gives $\mathbb{E}_x Y^4 \le (|x| + (3S)^{1/2})^4$, up to constants, hence $|F| \le C\lambda(|x|^3 + S^{3/2})$. Also $\hat{R}$ is continuous at $S = 0$, since the posterior concentrates at x. So $\pm\hat{R} - \beta - \varepsilon\chi$ is negative on the boundary of a large cylinder, hence inside it. Let the cylinder grow and then $\varepsilon \to 0$. □

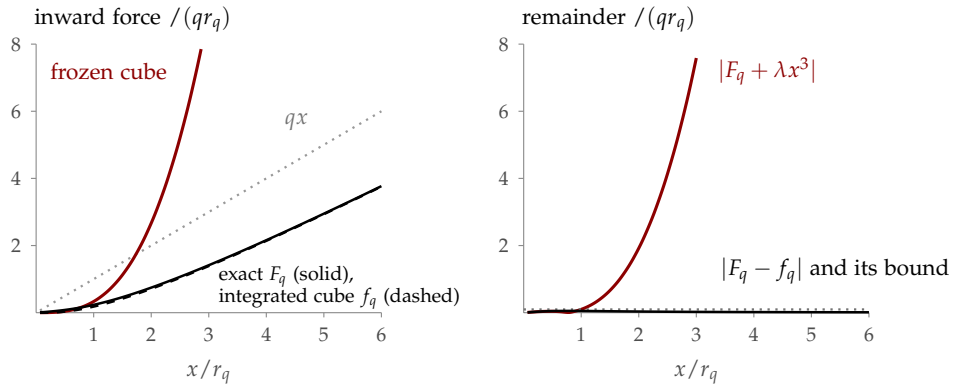


Figure 12.1. The force on one site, for $\lambda = 1$, $q = 4$. Left: the frozen cube leaves the exact force at $x \sim r_q$, while the integrated cube follows it at all fields. Right: the remainder of the frozen cube grows like the cube itself, while the remainder of the integrated cube stays below the bound of Theorem 12.8.

What this says about the choice of equation. The comparison on one site is summarised as follows, for $|x| \gg r_q$.

	frozen cube, clipped corrections	integrated cube
growth of f	cubic	linear, as for F
remainder $\lvert F-f\rvert$	$\sim\lambda\lvert x\rvert^3$	$\le 2C_*(\lambda/q)^{1/2}$
Burgers defect	$3\lambda^2 S^2 x^5$	$q\,b_q(y)$, bounded by $C_*\lambda^{1/2}q^{-3/2}$

The integrated cube is the forecast coordinate. The equation $qy+\lambda y^3=qx$, at $x=\Phi_q=P_q/q$, is the coordinate equation of Exercise 10.4, so $y_q(\Phi_q)=Y_q$. Equations (12.7) and (12.14) then say that $F_q-f_q=q(m_q-y_q)$: the remainder is K_qZ_q, and the error Z of (10.15) is the posterior mean minus the posterior mode. By (12.16), on one site $\lvert Z_q\rvert\le 2C_*\lambda^{1/2}q^{-3/2}$ surely, for all fields.

Why Wetterich has no such problem. In the variable y the bare quartic does not flow at all: all the trees of (b) are contained in the map $x\mapsto y$. The right side of (10.13) is a loop, and the defect $e_q(y)=-\frac{1}{2}[H_q(y)-S]$ of $\bar\Gamma_q=\frac{\lambda}{4}y^4$ is bounded by $S/2$. This is why Section 12.2 can leave the quartic untouched and clip only the corrections: what is clipped consists of loops, not of trees whose large-field sum is forced to change the growth of the action. This removes the frozen-cube problem specifically: the clipping error of Section 12.3 is still there, and it is what Lecture 6 pays for.

Where the coercivity is. Compare the same observation written in the two coordinates:

$$qy+\lambda y^3=P_q,\qquad qx=(q-q_0)m_q(x)+\eta_q.$$

In the coordinate y the cube is genuine, with the known right side $P_q=(q-q_0)\psi_q+\eta_q$. This is the equation (13.4) of Lecture 6, whose coercivity the a priori estimates exploit. In the coordinate x the cube has already been used up, and only a linear restoring force is visible.

What the model points to. What the scalar model points to is the integration of the cube. The Wetterich equation and the FBSDE of Theorem 10.6 are one way to organise it; another would keep the original field, with $f^{(0)}$ given by the variational formula of (a), and work with the defect $\frac{1}{2}\mathrm{Tr}(C_q^2D^2f^{(0)})$. On the lattice the variational formula still defines this force, with a nonlocal response, but its defect contains the loop contractions, starting with the tadpole, and must be renormalised. A complete proof along that route is not given in these lectures.

The scalar model proves less than a no-go theorem. It shows that a global estimate treating the remainder of a frozen cube as a small cubic perturbation is false. It does not show that every construction based on the Polchinski equation fails, nor does it give the asymptotics of the force on the lattice. There is also a limit to the integrated cube itself. With a quadratic term, the map $y\mapsto y+S(\lambda y^3+ry)$ has derivative $1+S(r+3\lambda y^2)$, which vanishes somewhere when $1+Sr<0$ (Exercise 12.7). A divergent negative mass cannot simply be placed inside this monotone map, and this is one reason why the mass correction M_q of (12.1) is kept apart from the quartic and is required to be small relative to K_q (Lemma 12.1).

12.5 Summary

At the end of this lecture we have, at every lattice cutoff:

- a counterterm μ_N, a mass path M_q and a globally convex action $\bar\Gamma_q=U+\frac{1}{2}\langle y,M_qy\rangle+h_q^{[2]}\circ\kappa_q$, all deterministic and constructed without any information on ν_N;
- the exact FBSDE (10.16) for the approximate forecast Y and the error Z, with noise coefficients bounded as in Lemma 12.1;
- a source $b=b^{\mathrm{b}}+b^{\mathrm{l}}$, whose bounded-field part is integrable in the backward equation thanks to the two correction steps, and whose large-field part is controlled by sixth powers of Y on the large-field set.

Lecture 6 turns these deterministic bounds into estimates on (Y,Z) uniform in N.

Exercises

Exercise 12.1. **(Receiving a centred kernel)** Let Θ be a translation-invariant, even kernel with $\Theta 1 = 0$. With T_z the translation by z, $(T_z f)(x) = f(x+z)$, and using $C_q \Theta = \frac{1}{2}\int \Theta(z)\,(T_z + T_{-z} - 2)\,C_q\,\mathrm{d}z$, show that $\|C_q\Theta\|_{\mathrm{row}} \le C\,q^{-1/2} v_1(\Theta)$ if $\|(T_z + T_{-z} - 2)\,C_q\|_{\mathrm{row}} \le C q^{-1/2} d(0,z)$. Why is the absolute row mass of Θ not the right quantity?

Exercise 12.2. **(The scalar clipping error)** On one site, let $h(y) = -\beta\,\frac{\gamma^2}{4q^2}\,y^4$ (a quartic correction, β a fixed number) and $\bar\Gamma_q = \frac{\lambda}{4}y^4 + h(\kappa_q(y))$. (a) Show that $K_q + \bar\Gamma_q'' \ge q/2$ for all y if $\beta\gamma \le c\,q^2$. (b) Show that $b_q = b_q^{\mathrm{b}}$ for $|y| \le r_q$. For $|y| > 2r_q$ show that κ_q is locally constant, $b_q^{\mathrm{b}}(y) = 0$, and $b_q(y) = -\gamma y\,(q + \gamma y^2)^{-3}$, the drift of the pure quartic. (c) Conclude that on the large-field set the error is the whole drift of the trace term: it is comparable, for $|y| \approx 2r_q$, to the one-site bound $\gamma q^{-3}|y|$ on the whole drift (the analogue of $(g_q/q)|y|$, with $a_2(q) = q^{-2}$ in place of $q^{-1/2}$), but it vanishes on the ball. Compare with (12.4).

Exercise 12.3. **(Large fields are less noisy)** On one site with $\bar\Gamma = \frac{\lambda}{4}y^4$, show that the quadratic variation of Y is $\int H_q(Y_q)^2\mathrm{d}q$ and that $H_q(y)^2 \le (\gamma y^2)^{-2}$. Simulate the observation process for $\nu = \mathrm{e}^{-\lambda\varphi^4/4}\mu^{1/q_0}$ and plot P_q, $\Phi_q = P_q/q$, Y_q and ψ_q.

Exercise 12.4. **(The defect)** Check (12.15) and integrate it: show that $\int_q^\infty q'\sup|b_{q'}|\,\mathrm{d}q'$ equals the right side of (12.16). Why does the integration of the cube turn the x^5 of (12.11) into a bounded function?

Exercise 12.5. **(Depth of the expansion)** Let U be any approximate potential, $U^{\mathrm{c}} = U + \Delta$. Show that $\mathcal{E}_q(U^{\mathrm{c}}) = \mathcal{E}_q(U) + D_q\Delta - 2B(U,\Delta) - B(\Delta,\Delta)$. Which terms are controlled by the smallness of the truncation defect $\mathcal{E}_q(U)$? Take U the tree expansion up to order k, and Δ the clipping of its terms beyond the cube. What replaces $3\lambda^2 S^2 x^5$ in (12.11)?

Exercise 12.6. **(A companion identity does not give a sign)** For $U = \frac{\lambda}{4}x^4$ and $f = -U'$, let $\beta_q = (V_q - U)(\Phi_q)$ and $R = F - f$. Show that $\mathrm{d}\beta_q = -[\mathcal{E}_q(U) + \frac{1}{2}S^2R^2]\,\mathrm{d}q - SR\,\mathrm{d}W_q$. Show that in the bracket the sextic terms cancel exactly, and that what remains is $-\lambda S\,x^4(1 + o(1))$ as $|x| \to \infty$. Conclude that the bracket does not dominate a positive multiple of S^2R^2, so this identity is an algebraic cancellation, not a coercive estimate.

Exercise 12.7. **(Negative mass)** For $r < 0$, let $y \mapsto y + S(\lambda y^3 + r y)$. Show that it is monotone if and only if $1 + Sr \ge 0$. What happens to the minimiser in the variational formula when $1 + Sr < 0$, and to the solution of (12.13) with $f_\infty = -\lambda x^3 - r x$? Why does this not contradict the existence of the exact, smooth force F_q?

References

[BCG26] I. Bailleul, I. Chevyrev, M. Gubinelli. Stochastic observables and Wilson–Itô diffusions. In preparation.

[BFS83] D. Brydges, J. Fröhlich, A. Sokal. A new proof of the existence and nontriviality of the continuum φ_2^4 and φ_3^4 quantum field theories. *Comm. Math. Phys.* 91 (1983), 141–186.

[BG20] N. Barashkov, M. Gubinelli. A variational method for Φ_3^4. *Duke Math. J.* 169 (2020), 3339–3415.

[FBSDE26] M. Gubinelli. The massive Φ_3^4 field through forward–backward equations. Course notes, October 2026.

[FO76] J. Feldman, K. Osterwalder. The Wightman axioms and the mass gap for weakly coupled $(\Phi^4)_3$ quantum field theories. *Ann. Physics* 97 (1976), 80–135.

[GH21] M. Gubinelli, M. Hofmanová. A PDE construction of the Euclidean Φ_3^4 quantum field theory. *Comm. Math. Phys.* 384 (2021), 1–75.

[GJ73] J. Glimm, A. Jaffe. Positivity of the φ_3^4 Hamiltonian. *Fortschr. Phys.* 21 (1973), 327–376.